RELIGION

THE JAIN THRESHOLD



A SACRED GEOGRAPHY
The Sammedh Shikharji shrine in the Parasnath hills, Jharkhand

SOMNATH SEN

By Jumana Shah

The last few days of 2022 saw the usually reticent Jain community taking to the roads in protest in many cities of north India. The immediate trigger was two issues—a feeling in the community that the Centre was dilly-dallying on its demand to protect the sanctity of one of the community's holiest pilgrimage spots, Sammedh Shikharji on Parasnath mountain in Giridih district, Jharkhand; and secondly, government inaction over the desecration of the Charan Paduka of Lord Adinath in the Shetrunjay Hills in Palitana town, Bhavnagar, Gujarat in November 2022. Miscreants also broke a CCTV camera installed there later in mid-December.

With the protests heating up, the BJP government at the Centre and in Gujarat moved swiftly to reassure the rich and powerful minority community of their support. For Palitana, the Gujarat government erected a permanent police chowki as well as an eight-member task force to "look into other issues regarding the Jain pilgrimage spot". As regards Sammedh Shikharji, the Centre issued a memorandum to stop all tourism activities in the Parasnath Hills and the wildlife sanctuary area of around 49.3 sq. km. But the Jains are unconvinced and the protests have continued. At least two Jain monks have died since after going on indefinite fasts.

The Jains are a micro minority community, with an estimated global population of five million, a majority of whom live in Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, with a sprinkling in the south and in the eastern states. Despite their low numbers, they are considered a crucial constituency, not just because of their affluence but also because they are known supporters of the ruling BJP. In Gujarat, the Jains make up just 0.95 per cent of the population but have four MLAs in the 15th assembly. Former chief minister Vijay Rupani is a Jain; so are the Adanis.

THE COMMUNITY IS LIVID AT THE STATE'S 'INACTION' ON VIOLATIONS AT THEIR HOLY PLACES

In Palitana, the community claims it is a victim of the mining mafia in the region. "There is massive illegal mining going on all around *teerth dham* Giriraj in the Shetrunjay hills that has 865 Jain temples. We have met CMs (Rupani and Bhupendra Patel) in the past five years but to no avail. After we complain, the illegal activities, including sale of illicit liquor, stop for a while, but soon restart. It's a lawless area now," says Pranav Shah, a representative of the Sheth Anandji Kalyanji Trust that manages Jain